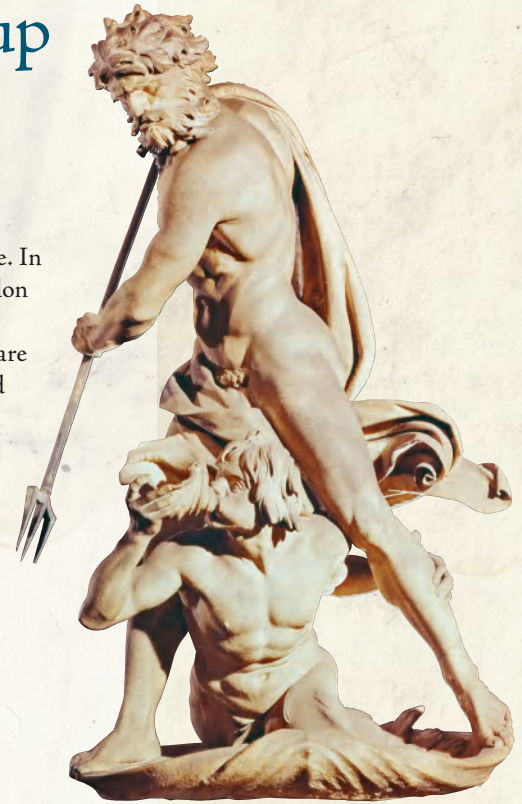


Poseidon, Sea Deities, Group Divinities, and Monsters

By the harbor there is a temple of Poseidon and a freestanding statue of stone. In addition to the many names that have been fashioned by the poets for Poseidon as an adornment for their verses, and those names which custom has established for each particular community, the names of the god that all men use are Pelagaios, (God of the Sea), Asphaleios (God of Security), and Hippios (God of Horses).

—PAUSANIAS, *Description of Greece* 7.21.7



POSEIDON, BEST KNOWN AS the great god of waters in general and of the sea in particular, was by no means the first or only such divinity. As we have seen, Pontus (Sea) was produced by Ge in the initial stages of creation; and two of the Titans, **Oceanus** and Tethys, bore thousands of children, the **Oceanids**. In addition, Pontus mated with his mother, Ge, and begat (among other progeny, discussed later in this chapter) **Nereus**, the eldest of his children, who was gentle, wise, and true, an old man of the sea with the gift of prophecy. Nereus in turn united with Doris (an Oceanid) who bore him fifty daughters, the **Nereids**; three of these mermaids should be singled out: Thetis, Galatea, and Amphitrite.

Peleus and Thetis

We have already mentioned that Thetis was destined to bear a son mightier than his father. Zeus learned this secret from Prometheus and avoided mating with Thetis; she married instead a mortal named Peleus, who was hard pressed to catch his bride. For Thetis possessed

the power of changing shape and transformed herself into a variety of states (e.g., a bird, a tree, a tigress) in rapid succession, but eventually she was forced to succumb. Peleus and Thetis celebrated their marriage with great ceremony (although she later left him), and their son Achilles did indeed become mightier than his father (see p. 481).

Acis, Galatea, and the Cyclops Polyphemus

Galatea, another Nereid, was loved by the Cyclops Polyphemus, a son of Poseidon. Ovid's account (*Metamorphoses* 13. 750–897) presents a touching rendition of their story, playing upon the incongruity of the passion of the monstrous and boorish giant for the delicate nymph. Repelled by his attentions, she loved Acis, handsome son of Faunus and a sea-nymph, Symaethis, daughter of the river-god, Symaethus, in Sicily. Overcome by emotion, Polyphemus attempted to mend his savage ways; he combed his hair with a rake and cut his beard with a scythe.

Ovid's Galatea tells how the fierce Cyclops would sit on the cliff of a promontory jutting out to the sea, where he would lay down his staff (a huge pine-trunk the size of a ship's mast) and take up his pipe of a hundred reeds. Hiding below in the arms of her beloved Acis, Galatea would listen to his song. First, he would extravagantly describe her magnificent beauty, then bitterly lament her adamant rejection of him, and continue with an offer of many rustic gifts. His tragicomic appeal concludes as follows (839–897):



Audio

“Now Galatea, come, don’t despise my gifts. Certainly I know what I look like; just recently I saw myself in the reflection of a limpid pool, and I was pleased with the figure that I saw. Look at what a size I am! Jupiter in the sky doesn’t have a body bigger than mine—you are always telling me that someone or other named Jove reigns up there. An abundance of hair hangs over my rugged features and, like a grove of trees, overshadows my shoulders; and don’t think my body ugly because it bristles with the thickest and coarsest of hair. A tree without leaves is ugly; ugly is a horse, if a bushy mane doesn’t cover its tawny neck; feathers cover birds, and their own wool is an adornment for sheep; for a man a beard and shaggy hair are only fitting. So there is one eye in the middle of my forehead. What of it? Doesn’t the great Sun see all these things here on earth from the sky? Yet the Sun has only a single eye. (839–853)

“Furthermore, my father Neptune rules over your waters, and he is the one I give you as a father-in-law. Only have pity and listen to the prayers of my supplication! I succumb to you alone. I am scornful of Jove, of his sky and his devastating thunder; but I am afraid of you; your wrath is more deadly than his thunderbolt. (854–858)

“I should better endure this contempt of yours, if you would run away from everybody; but why do you reject me and love Acis? Why do you prefer Acis to my embraces? Yet he may be allowed to please himself and you as well—but I don’t want him to be pleasing to you! Just let me have the chance. He will know then that my strength is as huge as the size of my body. I’ll tear out his living innards, and I’ll scatter his dismembered limbs over the land and the waves

10

20

of your waters—in this way may he mingle in love with you! For I burn with a fiery passion that, upon being rejected, flames up the more fiercely and I seem to carry Mt. Aetna, with all its volcanic force, buried in my breast. And you, Galatea, remain unmoved.” (859–869)

After such complaints made all in vain, he rose up (for I saw it all) and was unable to stand still, but wandered the woods and his familiar pastures, like a bull full of fury when his cow has been taken away from him. Then the raging Cyclops saw me and Acis, who were startled by such an unexpected fright. He shouted, “I see you and I’ll make this loving union of yours your last.” That voice of his was as great as a furious Cyclops ought to have; Aetna trembled at his roar. But I was terrified and dove into the waters nearby. My Symaethian hero, Acis, had turned his back in flight and cried, “Bring help to me, Galatea, help, my parents, and take me, about to die, to your watery kingdom!” (870–881)

The Cyclops, in hot pursuit, hurled a section torn out of the mountain. Although only a mere edge of that jagged mass struck Acis, it buried him completely; but it was through me that Acis appropriated to himself the watery power of his ancestry—the only solution allowed by the Fates. Red blood began to trickle from out the mass that had buried him, and in a short time the red of the blood began to disappear and it became the color of a stream made turbid by an early rain, and in a while the water cleared. Then the mass that had been thrown upon him split open and, through the cleft, a reed, green and slender, rose up and the hollow opening in the rock resounded with the leaping waves. Suddenly a wonderful thing happened—up to his waist in the midst of the waves there stood a youth, the sprouting horns on his brow wreathed with pliant reeds. Except that he was bigger and his whole face the bluish green of water, this was Acis indeed turned into a river-god. (882–897)

Poseidon and Amphitrite

The third Nereid, Amphitrite, is important mainly as the wife of Poseidon; like her sister Thetis, she proved a reluctant bride, but Poseidon finally was able to win her. As husband and wife, they play roles very much like those enacted by Zeus and Hera: Poseidon has a weakness for women, and Amphitrite, with good cause, is angry and vengeful. They had a son, Triton, a merman, human above the waist, fish-shaped below. He is often depicted blowing a conch shell, a veritable trumpeter of the sea; he can change shape at will.

Tyro, daughter of Salmoneus, was loved by Poseidon, who disguised himself as the Thessalian river Enipeus (Homer, *Odyssey* 11. 245):

In the form of Enipeus did the Earthshaker lie by her at the mouth of the eddying river. About them rose a crested wave, mountainous in size, which hid both god and mortal woman.

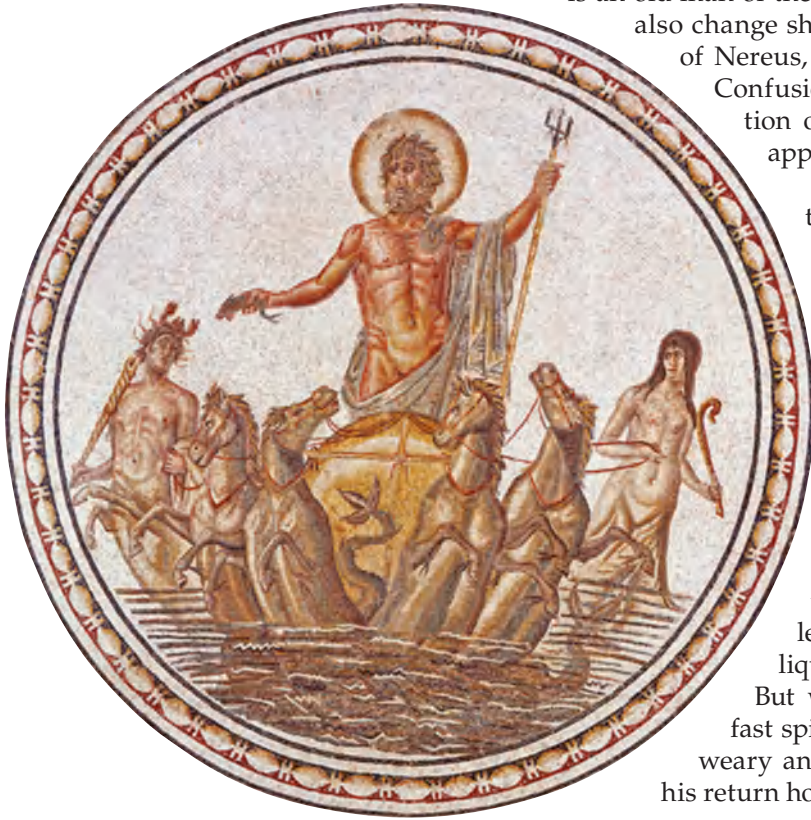
The children born of this union were twins, Neleus and Pelias, notable legendary figures with significant progeny.¹

For a translation of the accounts about Proteus by Homer and Vergil, see www.oup.com/us/morford.

Proteus

The sea divinity Proteus, probably another of the older generation of gods, is often named as the attendant of Poseidon or even as his son. Like Nereus, he is an old man of the sea who can foretell the future; he can also change shape. It is easy to see how the identities of Nereus, Proteus, and Triton could be merged. Confusion among sea divinities and duplication of their characteristics are everywhere apparent.

There are two classic accounts of Proteus' nature and his powers: those of Homer (*Odyssey* 4. 360–570) and Vergil (*Georgics* 4. 386–528). In Homer, Menelaüs, on his way home from Troy, was unduly detained off the coast of Egypt; he consulted Proteus, the old man of the sea, with the help of Proteus' daughter Eidothea. Menelaüs explains: "We rushed upon him with a shout and threw our arms about him; but the old man did not forget his devious arts. First off he became a thickly maned lion, and then a serpent, a leopard, and a great boar. And he became liquid water and a tree with lofty branches. But we held on to him firmly with steadfast spirits." Finally, the devious Proteus grew weary and answered Menelaüs' questions about his return home.



Neptune in His Chariot.

Mosaic, mid-second century A.D., diameter 77 in. This is the central panel of a very large square mosaic of *Neptune and the Seasons*, in which female figures representing each of the four seasons occupy the corners. Neptune (Poseidon) dominates the central panel, with four sea-horses pulling his chariot: to the viewer's right in the background is a sea-nymph, and on the left is a Triton. The theme was elaborated by Poussin in his *Triumph of Neptune and Amphitrite* (see image on p. 171). (Gilles Mermet/Art Resource, NY)

The Appearance and Character of Poseidon

Poseidon is similar in appearance to his brother Zeus, a majestic, bearded figure, but he is generally more severe and rough, to illustrate his tempestuous nature; besides, he carries the trident, a three-pronged fork resembling a fisherman's spear. By his very nature, Poseidon is ferocious. He is called the supporter of the earth but the earthshaker as well, and as a god of earthquakes he exhibits his violence by the rending of the land and the surge of the sea. By a mere stroke of his trident, he may destroy and kill. Ovid provides a typical description in his version of the Flood (see p. 100), providing a vivid characterization of Poseidon under his Roman name of Neptune. Poseidon's relentless anger against Odysseus for blinding Polyphemus provides a dominant theme in the *Odyssey*. The *Homeric Hymn to Poseidon* (22) attempts to appease his anger.

About Poseidon, a great god, I begin to sing, the shaker of the earth and of the barren sea, ruler of the deep and also over Mt. Helicon and the broad town of

Aegae.² A double honor, the gods have allotted to you, O Earthshaker—to be both a tamer of horses and a savior of ships. Hail, dark-haired Poseidon, who surrounds the earth and, O blessed god, be of kind heart and protect those who sail your waters. (1–7)

The origins of Poseidon are much disputed. If his trident represents what was once a thunderbolt, then he was in early times a god of the sky. More attractive is the theory that he was once a male spirit of fertility, a god of earth who sent up springs. This theory fits well with his association with horses and bulls (he either creates them or makes them appear) and explains the character of some of his affairs. He mated with Demeter in the form of a stallion; he pursued her while she was searching for her daughter, and her ruse of changing into a mare to escape him was to no avail. Thus, we have the union of the male and female powers of the fertility of the earth.³ It nevertheless should be remembered that standard epic epithets of the sea are “barren” and “unharvested” as opposed to the fecundity of the land. The suggestion that Poseidon’s horses are the mythical depiction of the whitecaps of the waves is not convincing, at least in terms of origins.

The important story of the contest between Poseidon and Athena for control of Athens and its surrounding territory, Attica, is told in Chapter 8 in connection with the sculpture of the west pediment of the Parthenon.

Scylla and Charybdis

Poseidon made advances to Scylla, the daughter of Phorcys and Hecate. Amphitrite became jealous and threw magic herbs into Scylla’s bathing place. Thus, Scylla was transformed into a terrifying monster, encircled with a ring of dogs’ heads. Ovid’s different version of Scylla’s transformation (*Metamorphoses* 13. 917–968; 14. 1–71) is more well known: Glaucus, a mortal who had been changed into a sea-god, fell in love with Scylla; when he was rejected, he turned to the sorceress Circe for help. But Circe fell in love with him and, in her jealousy, poisoned the waters of Scylla’s bathing place.

Scylla’s home was a cave in the Straits of Messina between Sicily and Italy. With her was Charybdis, the daughter of Poseidon and Ge, a formidable and voracious ally whom Zeus had cast into the sea by his thunderbolt; three times a day she drew in mountains of water and spewed them out again. Scylla and Charybdis have been rationalized into natural terrors faced by mariners when they sailed through the straits. Certainly, many of the tales about the gods of the waters are reminiscent of the yarns spun by fishermen, sailors, and the like, whose lives are involved with the sea and with travel.

The Progeny of Pontus and Ge

Pontus and Ge produced legions of descendants. (Notice how elements of the fantastic and the grotesque appear again and again in the nature of the progeny associated with the sea and the deep.)

In addition to Nereus, Pontus and Ge had two more sons, Thaumas and Phorcys, and two daughters, Ceto and Eurybië. Thaumas mated with Electra

Raphaël and Poussin

Raphaël (Raffaello Sanzio or Santi) stands with Leonardo and Michelangelo as one of the great masters of the High Italian Renaissance. He was born in Urbino, and during his early career he worked in Umbria and Tuscany, especially in the city of Florence. He was an accomplished painter and architect. In 1508, at the behest of Pope Julius II, he went to Rome and remained there until his death. One of the first works, if not the first work, that Raphael painted in Rome was the *Galatea*.

The most important sources for the story of Galatea are the *Idylls* of the Greek poet Theocritus (third century B.C.) and, of course, the *Metamorphoses* of the Roman poet Ovid (43 B.C.–ca. A.D. 17). In Ovid's version of the tale, the Trojan Aeneas is sailing past Scylla and Charybdis. This encounter leads Ovid to recall that once Scylla had been a beautiful, young woman pursued by many suitors. She would often visit Galatea to gossip about the latest suitor she had rejected. During one of these visits, Galatea contributes her own story at Scylla's urging. Galatea had once been the object of the love of the barbarous Cyclops, Polyphemus. He would often sing to her in an attempt to woo her, but Galatea spurned his advances; she had eyes only for a handsome youth named Acis. One day, Polyphemus caught them together and buried Acis under a mountain of stone. Galatea, however, had the power to trans-

form her beloved's blood, which was seeping out from between the rocks, into a river, and so Acis became a river-god. (Interestingly, there exists a variant of the tale in which Polyphemus' suit is successful and he wins the hand of Galatea.)

The classical tale was later used in a poem by the famed Italian scholar and poet Angelo Poliziano (1454–1494); his version was one of the main literary influences for Raphaël's fresco. In Raphael's version of the story, neither Polyphemus nor Acis is present, though shortly after Raphaël painted his *Galatea*, another artist,



Closer Look

Galatea, by Raphaël (1483–1520); fresco from the *Sala di Galatea* in the Villa Farnesina, ca. 1512; 116 × 88½ in. Galatea, riding in a seashell chariot drawn by dolphins, appears as the image of ideal beauty. Two Tritonesque figures, turning outward on her left and right, are blowing their seashell horns. Two pairs of lovers (one a merman and nymph; the other a centaur and nymph), carefully placed on either side of Galatea, embrace. Beneath her a cupid playfully mirrors Galatea's movements and the direction of her gaze. At the top, three cupids are seen converging their arrows on the scene below, and one cupid in the top left corner is isolated, concealed in a cloud, and keeping a firm grip on his arrows. The emotional tone of the whole is one of exuberant joy. (Alinari / Art Resource, NY / © Artres)



Sebastiano del Piombo, painted to the left of Raphaël's work, on another section of the wall, a fresco of the Cyclops entitled *Polyphemus*. This addition gives Galatea an object for her gaze. If considered alone, Galatea in Raphaël's fresco is neither gazing at anyone nor being gazed upon; she stands strangely isolated amidst the activity and amorous pursuits of the other figures. Many have seen in her a symbol of love itself; it is worth noting that she rides on a shell, a symbol that is often associated with Aphrodite (Venus). This vision of the apotheosis of Galatea had a tremendous influence on later artists.

The French painter Nicholas Poussin (1594–1665) was drawn to the past, especially the history and mythology of classical antiquity. Like Raphaël, he was attracted by Rome and spent all of his working life there; Raphaël's work exerted a profound influence on his style and composition. This can certainly be appreciated in *The Triumph of Neptune and Amphitrite*, although the subject matter is different, the color palette darker, and the scene more emotional. Amphitrite occupies the same space as Galatea; she rides in a seashell chariot drawn by dolphins and is the central focus of the surrounding figures. Since both Galatea and Amphitrite were daughters of the sea god Nereus, this association makes perfect sense. Neptune occupies the same place as the Cyclops Polyphemus in Piombo's fresco; he is the father of the Cyclops and, from the left side, is gazing adoringly at Amphitrite. Although the cupids are multiplied and disposed in various ways at the top, they do correspond to Raphaël's cupids, particularly the one beneath Amphitrite's chariot. The two Triton figures and the amorous couples are also replicated on either side of Neptune's consort. In myth, Amphitrite, like Galatea, spurned the advances of Neptune, at least at first. Poussin's painting reveals the end of the story.



The Triumph of Neptune and Amphitrite, by Nicolas Poussin (1594–1665); oil on canvas, ca. 1637, 45 × 58 in. Amphitrite is at the center, accompanied by Nereids and Tritons as she rides over the sea in her shell drawn by four dolphins. Neptune comes alongside his bride in a chariot drawn by four sea-horses. Above, winged cupids (one with butterfly's wings and one with a wedding torch) strew flowers, and in the background to the left ride two cupids, above whom fly the swans of Venus. Poussin exuberantly reinterprets a theme found in Roman floor mosaics and in Raphael's fresco *Galatea* (ca. 1512) in the Villa Farnesina at Rome. (Philadelphia Museum of Art: The George W. Elkins Collection, 1932. Photo by Graydon Wood)



Closer Look

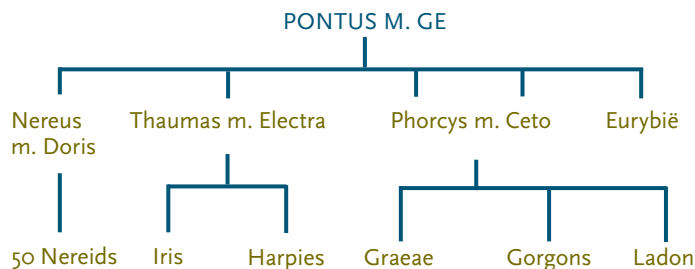


Figure 7.1. Descendants of the Sea

(an Oceanid) to produce **Iris** and the **Harpies**. Iris is the goddess of the rainbow (her name means “rainbow”). She is also a messenger of the gods, sometimes the particular servant of Hera, with Hermes’ offices then confined to Zeus. She is fleet-footed and winged, as are her sisters, the Harpies, but the Harpies are much more violent in nature. In early sources, they are conceived of as strong winds (their name means “the snatchers”), but later they are depicted in literature and in art as birdlike creatures with the faces of women, often terrifying and a pestilence.⁴

Phorcys and his sister Ceto produce two groups of children, the **Graeae** and the **Gorgons**. The Graeae (Aged Ones) are three sisters, personifications of old age; their hair was gray from birth, but in their general aspect they appeared swanlike and beautiful. They had, however, only one eye and one tooth, which they were forced to share among themselves.

The Graeae knew the way to their sisters, the Gorgons, who were also three in number (Stheno, Euryale, and Medusa) and whose hair writhed with serpents. They were of such terrifying aspect that those who looked upon them turned to stone. Gorgons are a favorite theme in Greek art, especially in the early period; they leer out most disconcertingly with a broad archaic smile, tongue protruding in the midst of a row of bristling teeth. **Medusa** is the most important

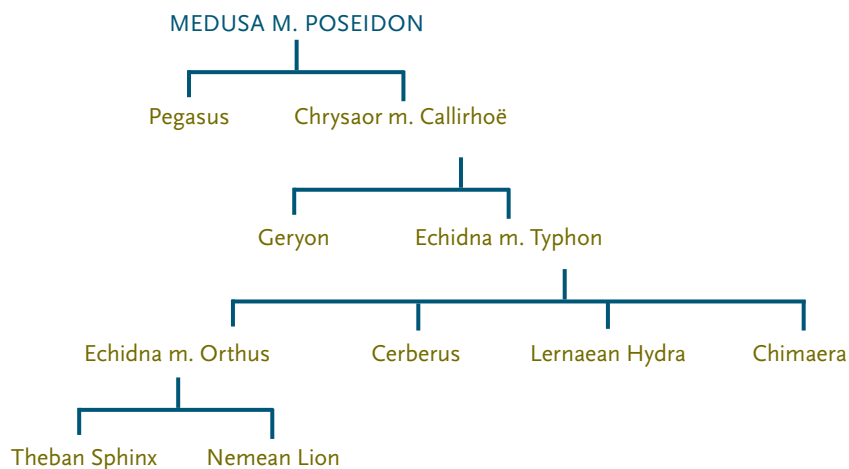
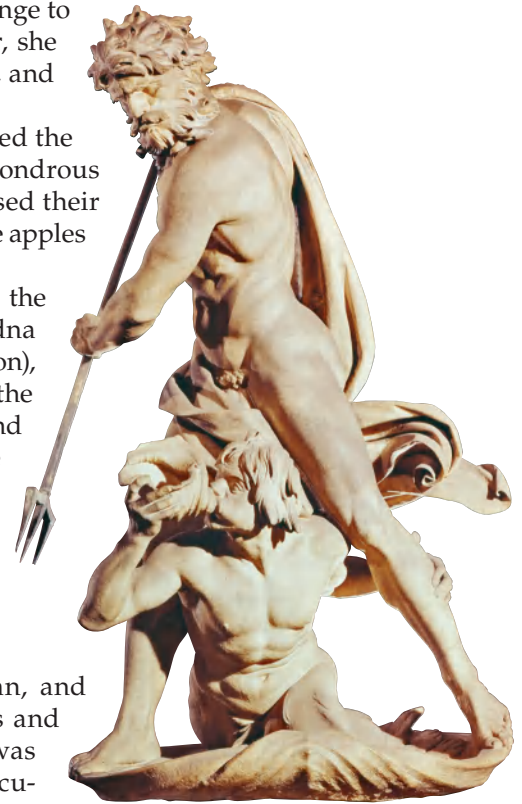


Figure 7.2. Descendants of Medusa

Gorgon; Poseidon was her lover. She presents the greatest challenge to the hero Perseus (see pp. 542–544), and when he beheaded her, she was pregnant; from her corpse sprang a winged horse, Pegasus, and a son, Chrysaor (He of the Golden Sword).

Phorcys and Ceto also bore a dragon named Ladon; he helped the lovely Hesperides (Daughters of Evening), who guarded a wondrous tree on which grew golden fruit, far away in the West, and passed their time in beautiful singing. Heracles slew Ladon when he stole the apples of the Hesperides (see p. 565).

Chrysaor mated with an Oceanid, Callirhoë, and produced the monsters Geryon and Echidna (half nymph and half snake). Echidna united with Typhon and bore Orthus (the hound of Geryon), **Cerberus** (the hound of Hades), the Lernaean hydra, and the Chimaera. Echidna and Orthus produced the Theban Sphinx and the Nemean lion. These monsters will appear later in saga to be overcome by heroes; many of them are particularly associated with the exploits of Heracles (see Chapter 22).



Interpretative Summary

The stories about waters of all sorts—rivers, lakes, the ocean, and the seas—and the deities associated with them are numerous and revealing. They remind us of how important travel by sea was to the Greeks and Romans and how control of the seas, particularly the Mediterranean, was the key to power. The thalassocracy (sea-power) of Minoan Crete makes this perfectly clear, as does the subsequent dominance of the Mycenaeans, the inheritors of Cretan control. Subsequently, the naval empire of Periclean Athens, in the fifth century B.C., confirms the vital importance of sea-power, and so does the mighty empire acquired by the Romans, for whom their Mediterranean “lake” was the central focus.

That there were two major periods in the initial creation of Greek mythology is made evident by the nature and extent of the travels of the seafarers, Theseus, Jason, Odysseus, and the survivors of the Trojan War in Minoan-Mycenaean times, with the conflation of geographical and historical events belonging to the historical age of colonization after 1100 B.C. From both periods evolved the turbulent and romantic tales about the various facets of waters and their deities and the sea monsters to be overcome by heroes.

We have shown Poseidon, the major god of the sea, to be characterized by ferocity and violence. He is “the earthshaker,” a deity of storms and earthquakes. His powers are made evident by his association with bulls and horses. He is the father of the monstrous Cyclops Polyphemus, and his inexorable anger is a major theme of Homer’s *Odyssey*. Poseidon lost to the goddess Athena in a contest for control of Athens, as we shall see in the next chapter. Yet the Athenians, great seafarers themselves, continued to give him great honor, and linked him particularly to their ancient king Erechtheus and his beautiful temple on the Acropolis. Poseidon was also said to be the true father of Theseus, the great national hero of Athens, through the human figure of Aegeus, an Athenian king, who gives his name to the Aegean Sea.

Neptune and Triton, by Gian-Lorenzo Bernini (1598–1680); marble, 1619, height 71½ in. Neptune (Poseidon) is shown striding forward angrily, supported by Triton blowing his conch. The scene is based on Ovid’s description of the Flood (see pp. 100–101: “Neptune struck the earth with his trident”). The statue stood above a pond in the gardens of the Roman villa of Cardinal Montalto, nephew of Pope Sixtus V. (V&A Images, London/Art Resource, NY)

Tales about waters are often yarns spun by sailors, full of abounding imagination, exciting adventure, and wondrous embellishment, embracing both the beautiful and the grotesque. Witness the fantastic variety in the character and appearance of the progeny of the sea. Poseidon is, like his domain, relentless and prone to stormy violence and anger. Yet gods such as Nereus and Proteus, profoundly wise, appear as ageless as the impenetrable sea itself. Still other deities mirror the unpredictable beauty and fascinating lure of the mysterious deep: the lovely mermaids, who can change shape and mood at will; the beguiling Sirens with their bewitching, lethal song; and monstrous Scylla and Charybdis, who bring terror, destruction, and death.

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Additional Sources

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Pausanias	<i>Description of Greece</i> 2.1.6–2.1.9: Poseidon's dispute with Helius; depictions of sea deities
Theocritus	<i>Idylls</i> 9: In which Theocritus tells a lovesick friend the song the cyclops sang to his beloved Galatea

Notes

1. Pelias became king of Iolcus (see p. 608) while Neleus founded Pylos (in Messene), which was sacked by Heracles. Neleus and all his sons, save only Nestor, were killed. Homer (*Iliad* 11. 682–704) says that Neleus survived into old age. Tyro later married her uncle Cretheus, the founder and king of Iolcus, and by him she became the mother of Aeson, Phereus, and Amythaeon. Aeson was the father of Jason, and Phereus, founder of Pherae, was the father of Admetus, husband of Alcestis. In order to marry Alcestis, Admetus had to perform the task of harnessing a lion and a boar together to a chariot. For the recovery of Alcestis from the Underworld by Heracles, see p. 266.
2. Poseidon Heliconius was worshiped by Ionian Greeks, especially at Mycale in Asia Minor. It is uncertain whether the reference in the hymn to Helicon (from which

Heliconius is derived) means Mt. Helicon (in Boeotia) or the town of Helice; Helice and Aegae were both on the Corinthian gulf.

3. The result is the birth both of a daughter and of the wonderful horse Arion, which belonged to the Theban Adrastus. Similarly, Poseidon united with Ge to produce Antaeus, a giant encountered by Heracles.
4. The horrifying Harpies are not unlike the beautiful Sirens, who lure human beings to destruction and death by the enticement of their song.

For additional resources related to this chapter, go to www.oup.com/us/morford.

Athena



And Athena pitied her companion and said to her: "It was not I who blinded your child Tiresias. It is not sweet for Athena to steal away the eyes of children. But the laws of Cronus decree thus: Whoever sees any of the immortals, when the god himself does not so choose, let him pay a great price for the seeing."

—CALLIMACHUS, *On the Bath of Athena*, 95–102

The Birth of Athena

The *Homeric Hymn* (28) tells the story of Athena's birth.

I begin to sing about Pallas Athena, renowned goddess, with bright eyes, quick mind, and inflexible heart, chaste and mighty virgin, protectress of the city, Tritogeneia. Wise Zeus himself gave birth to her from his holy head, and she was arrayed in her armor of war, all-gleaming in gold, and every one of the immortals was gripped with awe as they watched. She quickly sprang forth from the immortal head in front of aegis-bearing Zeus, brandishing her sharp spear. And great Olympus shook terribly at the might of the bright-eyed goddess, and the earth round about gave a dread groan and the dark waves of the deep seethed. But suddenly the sea became calm, and the glorious son of Hyperion halted his swift-footed horses all the while that the maiden Pallas Athena took the divine armor from her immortal shoulders, and Zeus in his wisdom rejoiced.

So hail to you, child of aegis-bearing Zeus; yet I shall remember both you and another song too. (17–18)